

Individual Contributor (IC) Growth Ladder and Expectations

Growth Ladder and Expectations

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Introduction

Purpose: This document provides approximate capabilities and expectations for software engineers at each level from P1 to P6. Success at Datavant includes both what is done and how it is done. This document focuses on expectations (“the what”), while [Our Values](#) focuses on the behaviors, values, and ways of working (“the how”).

This document is not meant to be a prescriptive list of to-dos for achieving the next level or a detailed Responsible-Accountable-Consulted-Informed (RACI) chart. Ultimately, everyone’s role is to help the team win by increasing shareholder value and **achieving our mission to make the world’s health data secure, accessible, and usable**. There are many ways to do that, and each engineer should play to their strengths and therefore will have impact in different ways. This document is meant to give guidance as to the scope of contribution expected at each level.

Audience: Software engineers and engineering people managers. For reference, the Engineering Manager Growth Ladder and Expectations document is accessible [here](#).

Data Science: Everything in this document applies to data scientists as well. Data scientists have a particular functional expertise, the same way that a frontend or infrastructure engineer does. While the example projects below are typical SWE projects, the same concepts apply to data scientists.

How do we think about growth?

We strive to hire high-aptitude (smart) high-agency (GTD) individuals and then put them in stretch roles where they can grow rapidly and build value for the business. With that in mind, Datavant is a library, not a classroom. We expect each individual to take ownership over their own growth and development, actively seeking out opportunities to learn and develop their craft and proactively asking questions and finding resources to learn more. Managers should help facilitate that growth by finding roles that maximize the product of the growth opportunity, the engineer's interests, and the business value (a specific type of sponsorship), by coaching and mentoring engineers on their teams, by finding opportunities for those engineers to work with other people who can help them grow, and by empowering them to more easily go find these opportunities for themselves. Managers are committed to facilitating growth in all these ways and investing in their team's success, and each individual is ultimately responsible for their own growth and success.

How to use this document?

Individual contributors should use this document to reflect on questions such as:

1. Self-Initiated Reflection

- a. What types of things can I do to achieve more impact for the team?
- b. Am I missing, meeting, or exceeding performance expectations for my role?

2. Career Growth

- a. What skills and knowledge can I develop to grow as an individual contributor?
- b. What projects need to be done where I'm uniquely qualified to create value?
- c. Given my superpowers, areas for increased impact, and learning goals, how do I want to grow as a professional and Datavanter over the next year?

Engineering Managers should use this document to:

1. Determine growth paths for their engineers.
2. Provide better, more targeted feedback.
3. Reflect on the performance of each individual on their team.

Key Considerations

Growth happens in many directions. We think of growth at Datavant as increasing impact via increased performance, scope, complexity, and independence. Some team members increase their impact by growing as individual contributors, others by growing as managers, and others by exploring new roles and charters within Datavant. We also know that Datavant may not be the best fit for all Datavantes at all times, and we're proud to have a strong alumni network (aka the Datavant Mafia) taking on impactful new opportunities.

Organizational impact is an important part of everyone's role. In addition to making significant functional/technical impact, Datavant expects all engineers to **accelerate the team**. Organizational and cultural contributions that move the team forward are not "distractions." Building and maintaining a healthy culture is part of everyone's job, and an important part of how we evaluate and reward impact.

<i>Examples of Organizational Impact</i>	
• Participating in the interview process • Knowledge transfer for a new onboard or upcoming departure • Documenting workflows • Team building activities (offsite / workshop / social events)	• Taking on an intern • Mentoring / Pair Programming • Continuous improvement initiatives • Conferences / publishing thought leadership

Focus on impact, not on title. This document could be summarized as “**the best way to advance as an engineer at Datavant is to increase your impact on the business.**” It is not designed to be a checklist for everything you need to do or every skill you need to have for the next level. Use the expectations as a guidepost to understand the type of impact you can have on the team. As you expand your skills, scope, and drive to grow, new opportunities will present themselves.

Capitalize on your strengths. Employees often focus on identifying and fixing their weaknesses to increase chances of success. We encourage you to lean into your superpowers and reflect on how you can create more impact than what’s expected of you.

Consistency matters. An engineer who performs like a P2 for a quarter, then does P4 level work the next quarter but then goes back to performing at the P2 level, is performing as a P2.

Scope and complexity matter. Expectations at each level are described below, and it’s worth noting that scope of the project matters. For example, it is possible to be a P5 by solving the most intricate and deep technical problems, even if you rarely interact with Product. Conversely, it’s possible to interface with product and design and still be performing at the P1 level if the problems you tackle are tiny, isolated components. Note that simple **solutions** are always preferred, regardless of the scope or difficulty of the problem or your level.

P3 is our “professional level”. We consider P3 our “professional level.” That means that we are perfectly happy with ICs who have P3 impact, and we expect that a limited number of engineers will progress to P4, P5, and P6. Conversely, when we hire engineers at the P1 and P2 levels, we expect them to continually increase their impact until they are delivering P3 level impact. Expectations for time at P1 and P2 are listed below. You might notice that the total time for a P1 to go to P3 is shorter at Datavant than when we hire externally; that’s because we believe that Datavant is an extremely high growth environment and engineers progress more rapidly here than they would elsewhere. If an engineer is in one of these levels for longer than the expected time, that’s a sign that the engineer is not growing as rapidly as we need to see. Datavant seeks to coach, mentor, and foster growth in all our engineers, and commits to investing in opportunities for our team to grow their impact over time. Only after significant investment to help our team grow would we consider a PIP, an exit, or mutually decide to part ways.

P1 - Software Engineer I

Expected time at this level: 6 - 12 months.

P1 is our entry level; A P1 typically joins Datavant with ~2-4 SWE internships, a BS CS or similar technical degree, and little to no full-time software engineering experience. While there are other paths to being hired as a P1 SWE at Datavant, this is the most typical.

As a P1, your manager gives you the why, the what, and the how for the work to complete, and you independently code the change, reaching out for institutional knowledge or help with complex technical concepts. You learn to manage the complexity of the code you add and work on avoiding scope creep with the help of your team. At this level you will still require supervision and input on most things. As a P1, you contribute ideas to the team, but they often require much more context, input, and refinement from your peers.

P2 - Software Engineer II

Expected time at this level: 9 - 18 months.

A P2 typically joins Datavant with 1-3 years of full-time SWE experience. Radford, our reference point for leveling and compensation, highlights a P2 as someone with a Bachelor's degree and a minimum of 2 years of related experience; or an advanced degree without experience; or equivalent work experience.

As a P2, your manager gives you the why and the what and you determine the how of the work you need to complete. You can break the work down into subtasks and design and implement those subtasks. A P2 rapidly contributes to the team at a code level reliably and without supervision. You are given a feature or new functionality to build, and you fill in the technical details, use appropriate abstractions, and think through reliability and future maintenance issues.

You proactively contribute ideas and initiate engineering efforts such as refactors and cleanups, performance improvements, etc. You are independent and have a good sense of ownership over the products you work on, either individually or as part of the team. At this level you are actively taking care of the codebase. You can be trusted to build features that your product/project needs without too much active involvement from your manager. You start dealing with more ambiguity in your projects. You reach out when needed, and ultimately make the judgment call as to whether to go one direction or another with a change. You start to get things done and provide a net benefit to the team, given that there is a more balanced exchange of help between you and your peers.

P3 - Software Engineer III

A P3 typically joins Datavant with 3-6 years of full-time SWE experience. Radford, our reference point for leveling and compensation, highlights a P3 as someone with a minimum of 5 years of related experience with a Bachelor's degree; or 3 years and a Master's degree; or a PhD without experience; or equivalent work experience.

As a P3, your manager gives you the why and some guidance on the what; you finalize the what, the when, the how, and sometimes the who. You own projects end-to-end. You work directly with product,

design, other Pods, and other stakeholders to establish requirements, make a plan, and execute. You break the work down into sub-projects, prioritize those sub-projects, and execute on each. You design the services or modules necessary to achieve the desired outcome. If you're the only one staffed on the project, then you implement all the designs directly; if other engineers are staffed on the project, then you work together to distribute the work and execute. If someone else's work falls off schedule, you course correct to keep the project on time. You provide feedback to those peers. You regularly mentor other engineers on the team, and you're often the subject matter expert (SME) on your Pod for multiple projects because you've worked on that code or technology in the past.

A P3 is fast and highly productive and delivers code at a rapid pace. You are a reliable and independent contributor that requires no oversight because you are trusted to raise issues and risks to your manager when they arise. You can lead projects with multiple engineers working on tasks and milestones within a larger scope. You establish expectations and timelines in alignment with goals cascaded to you from more senior engineers, engineering managers, or product leaders.

P4 - Senior Software Engineer

A P4 typically joins Datavant with 6 or more years of full-time SWE experience. Radford, our reference point for leveling and compensation, highlights a P4 as someone with 8 years of related experience with a Bachelor's degree; or 6 years and a Master's degree; or a PhD with 3 years experience; or equivalent experience.

As a P4, your manager gives you the why and you are able to develop everything else. **A P4 is able to own entire, long-lived products end-to-end.** A P4 is able to own big migrations end-to-end. A P4 is able to make significant improvements to our engineering operations and operational excellence. A P4 is able to partner **with product and design on the future roadmap of their product(s), working with other pods to ensure all their products work well together.** A P4 is often driving execution and identifying and solving problems across multiple projects. As a P4, you understand how to balance your own project expectations (or more than one project), while also doing a fair amount of work with other teams when it accelerates the team. You find significant design and continuous improvement opportunities. You have a deep understanding of how various teams make an impact and add value/support around some of their most challenging issues.

Some P4 expectations overlap with expectations of a Tech Lead and an Engineering Manager. That's intentional. While P4s are not people managers, they are still leaders on the team. P4s are not expected to do traditional people management work such as managing compensation or handling performance issues, but P4s often do mentor and uplevel the more junior team members around them.

A P4 has significant impact within their Pod and occasionally impacts beyond that to their entire vertical.

P5 - Staff Software Engineer

At the P5 level, there are many ways to be effective. This blog post concisely describes [4 common archetypes](#).

A P5 typically joins Datavant with more than 10 years of full-time SWE experience. Radford, our reference point for leveling and compensation, highlights a P5 as someone with a minimum of 12 years of related experience with a Bachelor's degree; or 8 years and a Master's degree; or a PhD with 5 years experience. Barriers to entry may require committee review.

A P5 might have built solutions impacting a large organization as a Staff or Principal engineer. A P5 might have spent time as an Engineering Manager, a Product Manager, a Designer, or in other roles. Similarly to P4s, there are many ways to be successful as a P5. The primary distinction between P4 and P5 is the scope and or complexity of your impact.

As a P5, you receive little to no guidance from your manager. Not only do you understand the current state of the team, but you can also identify what the needs of the organization are and drive projects across domains. Oftentimes, a P5's impact is across multiple pods or a whole vertical, but it's also possible to be a "Tech Lead" or "Solver" archetype P5 who dramatically accelerates the progress of a single pod. A P5 is the "go to" person for system knowledge, questions of team interfaces, design decisions and improvements, engineering and product ideas for what the team needs today, etc. all while delivering high quality individual contribution at speed. A P5 understands when to move fast and iterate quickly, and when to take it slow and optimize. As a P5, you should be ready to drop onto any team to help solve any class of problem, and able to identify where their time is best spent across a large swathe of potential investments.

A Staff engineer has a significant impact beyond just the scope of their Pod. They impact their entire vertical and possibly the entire enterprise. P5s often report directly to a Zone or Vertical Leader (often M4, M5, M6, or M7 engineering leaders), but they might also report into a specific Pod Manager (typically M2, M3, or M4 engineering managers).

As of today, we have very few P5s.

P6 - Principal Software Engineer

Radford, our reference point for leveling and compensation, highlights a P6 as someone with a minimum of 15 years of related experience with a Bachelor's degree; or 12 years and a Master's degree; or a PhD with 8 years experience; or equivalent experience. Significant barriers to entry (e.g., top management review, approval) exist at this level.

Everything that's true of a P5 is true of a P6. A P6's scope is much larger (e.g., enterprise-wide) and/or their work is significantly more complex (e.g., technical, business, or people complexity). As a result, their impact is also much greater and across several verticals.

A Principal engineer has a significant impact beyond just the scope of their Vertical. They impact at least multiple verticals and very likely they impact the entire enterprise. P6s almost always report directly to a

Zone or Vertical Leader (often M5, M6, or M7 engineering leaders) or even into the Office of the CTO. They rarely report into a specific Pod Manager (typically M2, M3, or M4 engineering managers).

As of today, we have only a couple P6s.

FAQs

Can I see my level?

Eventually your title and level will be available to you in Oracle, for now, ask your manager for your level.

Do P4s still write code?

Yes, definitely!

Do P5s and P6s still write code?

Almost certainly yes! I could imagine a P5 or a P6 who doesn't write code for good reasons. That would be the exception not the norm. Writing code keeps engineers grounded in the reality of the codebase, which increases the quality of their decision making and implementation.

How do we think about team composition?

Team composition is up to the engineering leader. We expect most pods to be a blend of P2s (~2) and P3s (~4) with one or two P4s (~2) for a total of approximately 8 engineers. Each vertical should have a few (~3) P5s. We only have a couple P6s across the entire enterprise; we expect to elevate a few more, but it's unlikely that we have more than a handful of P6s in the next few years.

What if I'm a P3 on a pod with all P4s and I don't see how to grow into a bigger impact?

As a first step, have a candid conversation with your manager about growth opportunities and/or growth concerns and work with them to discuss options to continue your growth. Our policy on talent mobility (recent [Slack thread](#)) is that ICs can move to a different pod as long as that new pod has an open headcount and that new pod's manager is excited to take them. In that case, the IC's original pod gets a backfill to hire (or take a transfer).

When we make offers, do we make them based on years of experience?

We should be making comp and leveling decisions based on the impact we believe the candidate will have i.e. we should make those decisions based on this doc and NOT based exclusively on years of experience. In many cases, years of experience are a good proxy and part of our consideration as to how we level a teammate.